

Seared pineapple and fire salsa

Use this salsa on burgers or tacos or in soup. If you have access to a barbecue, grill your pineapple strips. (Brush lightly with oil first.) If that's not convenient, follow the directions below for using a cast-iron skillet. Habañero (meaning "from Havana") peppers are **extremely hot** but also have a tropical fruit flavor. I find half a plump roasted habañero about the right heat. If you are a serious chilehead, use more—but hold on to your hat!

3 garlic cloves, unpeeled

1 fat, fresh habañero pepper

About ½ fresh pineapple, core removed, cut into 4 long wedges

2 teaspoons olive oil

2 tablespoons orange juice

1 tablespoon lime juice

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

½ teaspoon salt

3 tablespoons finely diced red onion, rinsed under cold water

¼ cup coarsely chopped cilantro [60ml]

1. **Toast** the garlic cloves and habañero pepper in a dry cast-iron skillet over medium heat until the garlic is soft and lightly browned in spots and the pepper is lightly blackened, 10 to 15 minutes. With tongs, turn the garlic and pepper. Lightly press down on the pepper often.
2. When the garlic is cool enough to handle, peel it. **Slice** the habañero in half, remove the stem, and scrape out the seeds and ribs. Coarsely chop half the pepper. Save the other half until you decide whether your salsa is hot enough or whether you need to add more.
3. In the same skillet, **sear** the pineapple in the olive oil over medium-high heat until the fruit is lightly charred on both sides, 1 to 2 minutes per side. Cut the pineapple wedges into chunks; reserve any juices.
4. Put the pineapple chunks and their juices in a blender or food processor. Add the toasted garlic and habañero, orange juice, lime juice, sugar, and salt. **Pulse** until

chopped and well blended; do not puree until smooth. Pour into a bowl and stir in the red onion and cilantro. Season with additional salt to taste. Let stand 30 to 60 minutes before serving, if you have time.

SERVES 3 TO 4

Epilogue on salsa

YOU HAVE TO WORK pretty hard to mess up salsa. In classes I've taught, I don't usually give an exact recipe; rather, I demonstrate one salsa and then give half a dozen ideas so students can make their own. Ultimately, you decide how bold your salsa will be or how many chiles to add. You decide whether there should be more or less cilantro or garlic or a splash of vinegar. The potential modifications are as plentiful as the flavors to choose from.

You've just read about several excellent salsas. However, if you've never made a salsa or aren't sure of the fundamentals, I thought I'd speed things up with a kind of basic, no-fail salsa suggestion guide or template to help you out. If you don't see something you'd like to include, go right ahead and add it. You can modify, multiply, or just be satisfied. Keep in mind my favorite old adage: The most successful people fail their way to the top.

Salsa guide

START WITH

Vegetable, fruit (raw or roasted), or beans. For example: tomatoes, tomatillos, corn, black or white beans, mango, peach, pear, avocado, and so on.

ADD (SINGLY OR IN COMBINATION)

Onion (red, white, yellow), shallots, scallions, chives, leeks, garlic (raw or roasted).

CHOOSE YOUR CHILE: (RAW OR ROASTED, SEEDED, RIBBED, OR LEFT INTACT)
Habañero (10), serrano (6–8), jalapeño (5–6), New Mexico (3–4)

What do the numbers mean?

10 = Beyond Hell, 5 = C'mon, you can take it!

1 = Wimp*

ADD

Chopped or whole cilantro plus hints of mint, thyme, or oregano

Lime juice

OPTIONS

Sugar, vinegar, salt

PREPARATIONS

Coarsely chop or pulse in food processor.

REMEMBER

Pay attention to colors and texture and let the flavors walk down the aisle for a while before serving.

*There are no "1s" in this book.